

UROMI JUSTICE DEVELOPMENT PEACE AND CARITAS INITIATIVES
(UROMI JDCPI) NEWSLETTER, March, 2021 Edition

CORPORATE FACT SHEET

Name	Uromi Justice Development Peace & Caritas Initiatives, (Uromi JDPCI).
Owner	Catholic Diocese of Uromi, Nigeria.
Legal Holder	His Lordship, Most Rev. Dr. Donatus Aimioshor Ogun (OSA)
Authorized Representative & Director	Very Rev. Fr. Dr. Fidelis Oriabure Arhedo
Corporate Registration No:	CAC/IT/No: 50042 & ED/MWASD/NGOR/200/04
Status	Catholic Non-Governmental, Non-Profit making, Humanitarian and Development Organization.
Motto	Hope for the Oppressed and Empowerment for All
Areas of operation	Integral Development, Human Rights, Democracy, and Good Governance, Alternative Dispute Resolution, Prison Apostolate and Legal Aid services, Peace Building, Micro-Credit and Caritas, TB and HIV/AIDS care and support, HIV Counseling and testing, Livelihood improvement, Anti-Human trafficking and VC programming
Project steered	Conflict Management, Training of Electorate, Election Observation, Budget Monitoring, Community TB Care, HIV/AIDS Awareness Creation & Counseling, Micro-Credit Facilities, Rural Community Development Enlightenment Campaign, Prisoners' Welfare Services, Gender And Child Rights, Widowhood Association, Human Rights, Training Programmes for Police Officers and Youths, Women Development & Promotion through Micro Credit, Emergency Response, Legal Aid, VC Programming, Capacity Strengthening for Good Governance, Campaigns and Sensitizations Against Human Trafficking as well as Creating Alternatives to Human Trafficking through Vocational Skills Acquisition and Empowerment, Human Right Education and Paralegal Scheme and Don't Pay With Your Life
Focus Group	The rural populace, the economically deprived, families, children, students, youths, women and widows living among the poorest of the poor in the society. Inmates in Prison and Ex-inmates, persons stigmatized with deadly diseases.
Physical Address	Inside Uromi Diocesan Chancery at Egbele, Uromi, Edo State, Nigeria.
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Auditors	1. Grant Thornton chartered Accountants Emgn, Benin Branch 2. Edforte, Fortne, Ehiagwina& Associates 141 Benin-Auchi Road Ekpoma, Edo State
Bankers	• UBA BANK PLC Mission Road, Uromi • ECOBANK PLC Mission Road, Uromi • FIDELITY BANK PLC Mission Road, Uromi • Unity Bank PLC Mission Road Uromi • Union Bank PLC Mission Road Uromi
Staff Strength	14
Number of Community Volunteers	65
Project Executed	16

INTRODUCTION

Uromi Justice Development Peace and Caritas Initiatives (Uromi JDPCI) continues in her developmental efforts to promote social justice and improve the knowledge of human rights of citizens through her human right intervention.

Uromi JDPCI held another phase of capacity building for the Paralegals and Human Right Advocates with focus on “psychological first Aid”. The Organization also facilitated quarterly review meeting of Paralegals for experience sharing and suggestions on best practices among the 26 communities in the Project area as well as conducted annual congress of paralegal.

Uromi JDPCI supported 30 young persons with start-up kits as part of efforts to reduce their vulnerability to human trafficking. Uromi JDPCI also supported 9 young female returnees with livelihood support to reintegrate them and provide them with means of survival. 8 caregivers were also supported with grant for income generating activities

In another activity, Uromi JDPCI partnered with US Embassy to support 30 OVC, older OVC and caregivers with vocational skills acquisition start up materials in Igueben community.

Uromi JDPCI Micro credit desk is still providing support to petty traders and active farmers through the disbursement of soft loans. Presently, the scheme has 55 active groups with a total of 537 persons benefiting from the different schemes.

HUMAN RIGHTS EDUCATION AND PARALEGAL SCHEME PROJECT

Quarterly Meeting of Paralegals

Uromi JDPCI held its 8th quarterly learning session with the Paralegals of the Human Right Clubs on the 15th of March, 2021. This very meeting being they last within the first phase of the project, Uromi JDPCI used it to review the achievements of the project, its challenges and suggestions on the way forward. A review of activities within the quarter was also carried out while the plans for the next quarter were outlined. A total of 63 persons (26 females, 37 males) made up of Paralegals, supervisors and staffs of Uromi JDPCI were in attendance.

The Executive Director Very Rev Fr Dr Fidelis Arhedo in his opening remark expressed joy and happiness over persistence, assiduousness and team spirit portrayed by the supervisors, paralegals and advocates of the various community human right clubs in carrying out assignments towards the achievement of project goal and objectives since the inception of the project. He stated that the project though coming to an end, was not winding up in failure, rather it was concluding with huge success, achievements, positive outcomes, results and impacts made in the various communities where the human right clubs were constituted. He explained that the influencing activities of the paralegals of the human right clubs in the communities showed that they understood all the rudiments of the intricacies of being worthy paralegals. He said this was only achieved because of their availability for trainings carried out, and their willingness to practice lessons learnt.



Very Rev. Fr. Dr. Fidelis Arhedo, giving his opening remark

He explained that the term paralegal was an internationally recognized frame that serves as first aid relief to victims of human right violations, within the geographical sphere it existed. He said that constituents of the groups were usually persons of proven integrity, reliability and uprightness, with zero tolerance to evil. He encouraged participants not to relent in their activities as paralegals and advocates of the human right clubs in their various communities especially now that the scheme was drawing close to its end. He explained that services of such rendered in the community were voluntary in nature without payment but propelled by the love of humanity and mankind.

Conclusively, he advised participants to uphold the rights and obligations of each other and to be careful not to prosecute innocent citizens of crimes alleged against them, by conducting proper investigations through best practices.

The meeting thereafter proceeded to review key activities conducted during the quarter. The first in this line was the training of paralegals on Psychological First Aid which was held on the 3rd to 5th of March, 2021. Members expressed satisfaction over the lessons learnt from the training, stating that it was apt and timely for the purpose of effective case managements in intervening in incidence of human rights violations in the community. They thanked the organization for their

initiatives in mapping out strategic plans for successful case managements. The project team then reminded the Paralegals that the current phase of the project would end by 31st of March while another phase is bid to commence soon. They were encouraged to keep the good work while we await the approval of the second phase. Some participant then asked if the human right advocates could still enjoy the support and assistance from the organization when the current scheme comes to an end. Possible support and assistance from the organization after the end of the current scheme was assured to the participants by the Program Manager Mr. Michael Iyoriobhe, stating that the necessary capacities have been built in the course of embarking on the project and as such the office could still support the movement with referrals to the Ministry of Justice in the cases related to sexual abuses. Going further, he informed participants of a report made by the Area Commander of Ekpoma Area Command to the organization stating the current state of affairs of a defendant in one of the incident cases of rape intervened by the organization. Also, they were advised to always keep their supervisors informed so that they could easily proffer counsel and assistance.

Reports from Supervisors

The first supervisor to present his report was Bar. Dan AKHIDENOR, supervisor of the human right advocates in Esan Central Local Government Area.



One of the supervisors giving report

In his report, he stated that the human right advocates have been diligent with their monthly meetings and sensitizations and that currently two reported incidences were being treated by the human right clubs in two communities, wherein he was actively involved. He informed participants that so far the activities undertaken were not such beyond his capabilities as well as

those of the human right advocates in the community. He therefore assured every one of the existence of peace and tranquility within his jurisdiction.

Barr Dom OKOJIE, the supervisor of the human rights advocates in Esan North East Local Government Area, reported that the human right advocates in the various communities dutifully observed their monthly meetings within the quarter as well as engaged in community sensitizations. Also he reported that an incidence of defilement was reported in one of the communities which on investigation, it was realized that the allegation was false and as such the case was thrown down. Conclusively, he emphatically appreciated the efforts of the paralegals and advocates of the various human right clubs within his domain. Stating that their enthusiasm, passion and willingness to learn more about human right was commendable and very gratifying. He related that their zest had made his input very easy and also minimal since they were willing to undergo activities in the community as at when due.

Barr EKEWE, E.C, supervisor for the human rights advocates in Esan South East Local Government Area reported, that the human rights clubs successfully carried out their meetings within the quarter, she also reported the Human Rights Club were instituted in two secondary schools in one of the communities, and ably supervised by one of the human rights advocates in the community, who happened to be the head teacher of the school. She related how supportive the various club members have been to her, how determined they were to continue the cause for justice while seeking for more encouragements to be given to the paralegals by the organization by seeing to the extension of the scheme, in order for it to fully owned and indigenized in the communities.



Supervisor from Esan North East giving report

They were congratulated for the successful leadership and influential roles they played while working with the various community human rights clubs and encouraged them to keep up with that standard.

Esan West Local Government Area commenced the reports.

Eguare Ekpoma Human Right Club reported that they carried out sensitization to National Union of Road Transport Workers and Okada Riders Association in the month of January, while in February, a case of assault of a pregnant woman which resulted to grievous bodily harm and undue labour was investigated and filled in Court. He further informed everyone present that the matter would commence in Court on the 7th of April, 2021.



Participant at the meeting

Egoro-Amede Human Right Club reported that they sensitized their community on child abuse. The paralegal reported case of child abduction which was brought to their notice. According to her, a woman complained to the advocates that her child who was under her custody was abducted by the family members of her husband and all efforts to retrieve the child were abortive. The paralegal reported that the advocates were trying to resolve the issue amicably through



Ukpenu Paralegal giving his report

Alternative Dispute Resolution Mechanism.

Ukpenu Human Right Club The paralegal reported challenges faced by the advocates after the death of two forerunners of the human right clubs in the community. According to them, home to home sensitizations were carried out by them in the community and hope to see that their efforts yield success in subsequent months.

Ukhun Human Right Club reported, that monthly meetings were observed by the advocates and that team of Uromi JDPCI also paid a visit to the advocates sometime in February. He stated that efforts were been made by the advocates to visit the community elders and chiefs in council.

Esan Central Local Government Area

Akho Human Right Club reported that monthly meetings were held, sensitization on gender and widowhood practices was also carried out to the elders in the community by the advocates and supervisor of the local government area, while an incident report of defilement was intervened on by the human rights advocates who ensured that the matter was dutifully followed up by the police, doctors report and post exposure prophylaxis were obtained while Uromi JDPCI, provided the necessary support and logistics for the realization of the steps taken above.

Usenu Human Right Advocate According to the Paralegal, monthly meetings were carried out. And two cases of child neglect/abuse and child trafficking were reported, investigated and successfully tackled by the Paralegals and advocates. A well-meaning member of the community supported one of the victims with monthly maintenance money while Uromi JDPCI provided educational support to one of the victims. She used the opportunity to appreciate the executive director, Very Rev. Fr. Dr. Fidelis ARHEDO as well his staff for their kind gesture.

Ewu Human Right club reported that they conducted community sensitization as well as intervened in an incidence of gender inequality. The female children of a deceased man were prevented from conducting the burial rite of their father in the community thereby depriving them of the right to inherit their father's property. Upon their intervention on the case, the children were allowed to perform the ceremony.

Idumebo Human Right club reported that meetings were successfully conducted in the quarter as well as sensitization of small groups of persons in the community on human right which led to high turnout of new members in the club.

Agua Human Right Club reported that they held monthly meetings and conducted community sensitization to improve the knowledge of human right and the need to prevent violations in the community.

Esan North East Local Government Area

IvueHuman Right Club reported that monthly meetings were carried out after which the advocates sensitized community members on gender equality and the rights of females to inherit the properties of their deceased father.

Erer Human Right Club reported a case of a person who was supposed to be given the title of family head as of right, but denied of it because it was alleged that he did not perform his customary responsibility to his late father. However, the same title was challenged by another who was guilty of the allegations against him. The human right advocates haven learnt of the

issue, realized that it was not equitable and therefore successfully resolved the matter through Alternative Dispute Resolution Mechanism and the community elders reinstating the right person to his rightful position as head.

Egbele Human Right club reported that they held monthly meetings wherein other community members invited to the meetings were sensitized on the issues of human rights violations.

Efandion Human Right Club reported that monthly meetings were observed by members and inter personal sensitizations were embarked upon by the advocates.

Amendokhian Human Right Club reported that they conducted community sensitization on sexual abuse and that an incident of defilement was reported to them by a parent. They in turn reported to the police but upon investigation the Doctor's report showed that there was no trace of defilement. The testimony of the child did not also support the allegation made by the parent. The Paralegals thanked Uromi JDPCI who provided the logistics for the medical examination and documentation

Esan South East Local Government Area

Ewohimi Human Right Club reported that they conducted monthly meetings and carried out community sensitizations as well as monitored the progress and outcome in determination of cases using community Alternative Dispute Resolution Mechanism.



Paralegal from Ewohimi Community giving report

Emu Human Right Club while presenting his report, the Paralegal stated that monthly meeting were carried



A paralegal giving her report

out, and that the advocates of the human right club in the community successfully settled the dispute that ensued in four quarters over the rightful ownership and use of the communal market through ADR.

Ahia Human Right Club reported that monthly meetings were observed and also informed participants of an incident of gender discrimination that occurred in the community, where the sharing of the property of a deceased man who had three wives were shared to all of the widows except the widow without a male child. The advocates advised the family against such acts repugnant to natural justice equity and good conscience and a consideration was made for the widow to have a share in the property.

Ubiaja Human Right Club, the Paralegal reported that monthly meetings were observed.

Okhuesan Human Right Club also reported that meetings were successfully held.

Ewatto Human Right Club reported that monthly meetings were held and that they also carried out community sensitizations on human right issues.

Igueben Local Government Area

Ebelle Human Right Paralegal reported that two incidents were handled by them within the quarter. First was the amicable settlement of a dispute that ensued in a family where a child of a deceased man claimed ownership of a family land, and an incident case of defilement which was perpetuated on a maternal orphan in the community. They have reported the case to the Police who have commenced investigation, however, search of the perpetrator was still on going as he has fled from the community.

Uhe Human Right Club, formally addressed as Idumekhan Human Right Club reported that monthly meetings were held and sensitization of community elders to make certain ratification on proposed improvement to cultural practices was ongoing.

Eguare Igueben Human Right Club reported that they held their monthly meeting as well as community sensitizations on human rights issues. They added that they also monitored the progress of proceeding in court on the defilement case they earlier reported



Cross Section of Participants in the meeting

Under other issue, gender inequality was reported by a paralegal who said that a wife was driven out of her home because she answered a phone call, and whose caller was unknown to her husband. She explained that some human rights advocates had to intervene in the situation since the treatment meted on the woman was quite unfair and the issue was resolved amicably.

They were commended for their astute role in ensuring that peace was restored in that home through their successful alternative dispute resolution mechanism, and urged them to keep up with their good works.

Training of Paralegals on Psychological First Aid

Uromi JDPCI organized and carried out three days training of the paralegals on psychological first aid under the human right education and paralegal scheme project sponsored by Misereor. The training was necessitated by the desire to achieve successful case management of incidents reported to the paralegals and advocates of the human right clubs. This training was meant to build their capacity and improve their ability to see through the victims of human rights violation, creating trust for conducive healing and rehabilitation of survivors. The participants at the training were taken through some key terms such as mental health, psychosocial model,

IASC Pyramid of intervention, identity, crisis, emotional and physical reaction to stress, solution as well as the types and roles of actors. Other issues treated were; people in need of special attention, people at risk, vulnerability, resilience, coping, key principles in lay counseling, self and team care.

This training which was facilitated by Michael Iyoriobhe took place from the 3rd to 5th of March 2021 at the Chancery complex, Egbele, Uromi. A total of 114 persons (53Females, 61male) made up of the supervisors, the paralegals and advocates of the various community human right clubs in the 5 local government areas were in attendance.

The training started with registration of participants which was followed by setting of ground rules and expectations. This was preceded by the opening remark which was delivered by the Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI Very Rev Fr Dr Fidelis Arhedo, in which he acknowledged the presence of all participants and appreciated them for their unanimous approach to improve



The Executive Director, Very Rev. Fr. Dr. Fidelis Arhedo making his opening speech

the human right awareness level in their various communities and their effective response to human rights violation through their availability and activeness to activities facilitated by the project.

He reminded participants that the purpose of the training was to arm them with the techniques needed to assist and rehabilitate victims of human rights violations in their communities. He therefore enjoined them to listen attentively to the presentation as well as participate actively in the course of the training.

The first presentation was on mental health and psychosocial support, which were explained to the participants by the facilitator through a participatory approach. Mental health was described as the State of well-being in which an individual realizes his or her own abilities, can cope with normal stresses of life, can work productively and fruitfully, and is able to make a contribution to his or her community (WHO, 2002). While psychosocial was explained as interrelation of behavioural and social factors... to the interrelation between mind and society” (OED, 1997). It was further stated that mental health was not only the absence of mental disorder, nether was facing a crisis event by a person stipulates that one must develop mental disorder, however, he said that such persons should be aided without agonizing them further.

The facilitator then explained the psychosocial model which includes social economic, cultural anthology and bio-psychology. It was noted that, psychosocial approach refers to interrelation considered in all aspect of humanitarian assistance, while psychosocial programming includes support to the wellbeing of victims through recreation, counselling, cultural and social activities.

After the explanation of the key concept of wellbeing which where individual differences, (who a person is to his/herself), the internalized social factor, (gender, culture, traditions, traditional roles, etcetera) and how other persons perceive the individual which could also be a self-perception. The



Cross section of participants after the day one training



One of the participants making contribution

facilitator proceeded to make a presentation on crisis, crisis cycle, emotional and physical reactions to stress. According to him, crisis could be seen as an unusual situation with unprecedented experiences, which could result to intuitive reaction, which is isolated from planned action of reason. Then under the crisis cycle, he named and explained pre crisis, crisis, reparation, and early recovery. He advised that it was better to manage a situation from a pre-crisis stage before it escalated to becoming a crisis, however, where crisis situation occurs, reparation would lead to quick and early recovery of the victim.

He said crisis could be effectively managed when one takes a deep breath, going back to the drawing table, thinking before acting and planning or strategizing intended actions.

More so, he stated that there exist affected populations who tends to act and respond in typical approaches that could be described as the driven, who believes they have no chance to influence or have impact on the event; the sleeper or quitter and the secluded who evades changes and wants to retain their current situations; the Combatant who keeps looking for new approaches to change the situation and the explorer, who is opened to new and flexible options and opportunities.

He explained that the above named roles were very important in managing the case because the caregivers would be at risk of protecting the violence, distrust, and destruction if they were inflexible and continued to use only one role for all situations, regardless of their good intentions to improve and serve humanity. Also, he said that the care givers ability to adopt different positions enabled risk reduction by shortening the rigid role of the rescuer.

Conclusively, he informed participants of the fact that persons reacted to crisis differently. He said that while some persons may only be mildly distressed or not distressed at all, other would be totally broken. He again stated that most people tend to recover from such distress when their basic needs were restored, receive support from persons, especially those around them as well as get access to psychosocial first aid.

On the second and third day, participants in a role play showed how people reacted, behaved or responded in the local culture, when they were distressed. They showed the emotional reaction to anger, guilt and shame, as well as the physical reaction to stress, health palpitation and extreme fatigue.



Participant making his contributions

Also, participants reacted to the above shown emotional and physical reactions to stress, by becoming the humanitarian actors of a trainer,



The Facilitator taking participants through the training

therapist, interpreter, militant, reformer etcetera.

Participants also showed how they listen to complainants as well as helped them felt calm, by maintaining eye contact, nodding, by making sighs that showed that they understood the complainant, preventing distractions and unnecessary interjections, by making the venue very conducive for the complainant, etcetera.

This was followed with a presentation on vulnerability, in which it was explained that vulnerability differs from persons to persons, and spheres of human activities. The facilitator noted that persons could be socially vulnerable, financially vulnerable, medically vulnerable, psychologically vulnerable, emotionally vulnerable and even educationally vulnerable. Going further, he noted the fact that identifying people at risk did not necessarily mean that they were passive victims, although at risk people needed support, they often have capacities and social networks that enables them to contribute to their families and to be active in social, religious and political life.

The next presentation was on resilience, its factors and how to build it. According to him, resilience met adapting well in the face of adversity, crisis, tragedy, threats or significant sources of stress; such as family and relationship problems, serious health problems, or work place and financial stressors. He said the factors that determined resilience include; personal attributes, situation at the time of the critical event, that is, its severity and magnitude. He also said resilience could be built through information, expression and experience sharing, emotional and practical support, sense of safety, calming, community and self-efficacy, connectedness and instilled hope.

Also, he said that everyone had a coping ability which was the act of dealing with personal crisis arising from significant or traumatic life event, and it could be strengthened or promoted.

He said in Lay counseling, empathy, which is the act of trying to work in someone else shoes; respect, which is the act of warm acceptance of a person just the way they are; and authenticity which is the act of being real, were principles to be adopted by a lay counselor. Also, he stated that lay counseling entailed active listening, information sharing and support of informed decisions. He listed the dos and don'ts of a lay counselor among others

Again he emphasized the importance of mastering the art of listening to complainants; because it helped to support decision making, clarify questions and provide relevant practical information, support to identify possible solutions, and try to guard against wrong decisions, as well as accompany, support and coach rather than direct advice. The need to understand the point of view of a help seeker was further emphasized

Again, he noted that peer support could also help the complainant out of their crisis because such peer supports provides empathy, concern, respect and even trust.

A presentation on maintaining self and team care so as to avoid burn out was made. This he said was necessary because as humanitarian assistance had many rewards, it also carries certain risks and responsibilities. He said that such responsibilities could come with stress and the ability to manage the stress was key to achieving success in life.

the training was concluded by reiterating the dos and don'ts of PFA which admonishes a lay counselor to avoid the use of technical terms, avoid giving false promises and untrue pledges, avoiding thinking and acting to solve all the problems of the complainant, as well as avoid the use of negative attribute such as stupid or crazy to attribute others.

Participants expressed delight and satisfaction with the presentations and lessons learnt and appreciation to the facilitator and team members of Uromi JDPCI. They unanimously promised to effect the message passed in current and subsequent incident cases.

Annual Congress of Paralegals

The conference served as a closeout dissemination meeting as well as a platform to appraise our efforts and performance and that of our collaborators in the Human Rights Education and Paralegal scheme Project which began on the 1st of April, 2019. It also provided opportunity for our relevant stakeholders to critic the Project and make recommendations for improvement in subsequent interventions.



Cross session of participants after the day two training

A total of 350 Participants were in attendance for the conference and comprised: The President of Irrua Customary Court, The Area Commanders of Ekpoma, Irrua and Uromi Commands, Representatives from the DSS and NSCDC, Representatives of the Onojie of Igueben, Ubiaja, Ewohimi and Ewatto, Catholic Priests of Uromi Diocese, Community representatives from 26 communities across the five Local Government Areas (LGAs) in Edo Central Senatorial District, the five Local Government Area Supervisors of the Project, Paralegals, Human Rights Advocates and Staff Members of Uromi JDPCI.



Group photograph with participants at the event

The convener of the Conference and Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI; Very Rev. Fr. Dr. Fidelis Arhedo in his opening remark made a detailed presentation of the background, goals and strategic objectives of the project. He also highlighted the various activities that were conducted throughout the span of the project. He noted that the intervention which was aimed at contributing towards an improved peaceful co-existence of the village community and promotion of social justice and respect for human rights commenced with Advocacy to relevant



A participant asking questions at the event



A participant making a contribution at the event

Stakeholders and line Ministries, selection and identification of Paralegals and Human Right Advocates, inception/ orientation meeting, Capacity building sessions for Paralegals and Human Right Advocates, Gender Sensitization on participation of women in social economic and political life and ill treatment of Widows and widow inheritance amongst Others. He emphasized that the intervention focused on capacity building and training geared towards promotion, protection and prevention of human rights and human rights violations respectively. He

thereafter enumerated some of the challenges encountered in the implementation of the project to include

- **Lack of interest** to report human rights violation by community members
- **Exorbitant fees** charged by hospitals to produce medical reports for victims of rape or defilement
- **Inadequate Logistic support** for security agencies to refer cases of rape or defilement to their headquarters in Benin
- **Inadequate human rights Lawyers** that provides Pro-bono services
- **Delay in the administration of justice:** some of the cases we are tracking have lingered on for over one year
- **Poor people's perception and understanding** of the justice system
- **Community sanctions** that prevent people from reporting human rights violations including rape and defilement to the Police



Participants at the event

He concluded by suggesting the following recommendations as way forward:

- Increase awareness of human rights among communities through dialogues and sensitizations
- Hospitals should be encouraged to assist indigents victims with medical report as part of their social responsibility
- He appealed for regular improvement in the allocation of logistics to the security agencies for effective referrals
- The social welfare department in the various LGAs should be strengthened to assist indigent citizens with access to logistics and other services needed for effective rehabilitation
- He appealed to the NBA and Catholic Lawyers association to give kind assistance to indigent victims who may not be able to afford the services of a Lawyer. This will go a long way to deter abusers knowing that there are Lawyers who would stand for justice irrespective of the economic, political and social status of those involved

- Traditional institutions should avoid interference in criminal cases, as this perpetuates the occurrence of criminality in the communities
- Encourage the sensitization of in school adolescents on the importance of human rights protection and the need to report human rights violations to appropriate authorities

He thanked all Stakeholders who contributed in one way or the other to the successes recorded in the Project.



A section of participants at the event



Another section of participants at the event

ACP Akeke Enimijofa, the Area Commander, Nigerian Police Force Ekpoma Area command who was one of the guest speakers at the event, made a presentation on “the Role of the Police and Citizens in addressing Human Rights Abuses”. He stressed on the need for increase collaboration between the police and citizens in reporting, investigation and prosecution of offenders and then encouraged participants to abreast themselves with basic knowledge of fundamental human rights so as to effectively reduce extortion and abuses. He admonished the people to use the services of a lawyer should they feel their rights were being violated by the Police or any other person. The other guest speaker Hon Gladys Ikhuorah Esq, the president of Irrua Customary Court spoke on “Cultural Practices, Regulation and interference with Human Rights in the Communities (Widowhood Practices, wife inheritance and female right to



ACP Akeke Eni making a presentation



Figure 1 Barr Mrs Ikhuoria G making a presentation

inheritance)". She said that widowhood practices

and wife inheritance were immoral, barbaric, dehumanizing and degrading traditional practices which should be shunned and expunged from our communities.

Participants expressed their desire for a more committed engagement with key stakeholders to achieve peaceful and more enlightened communities where human rights are upheld and respected.

ANTI HUMAN TRAFFICKING

Uromi JDPCI Presents Start Up Materials to Beneficiaries

As part of efforts to reduce the susceptibility of vulnerable Children/youth and women to human trafficking and irregular migration in Esan land, Uromi Justice Development Peace and Caritas Initiatives (Uromi JDPCI), Catholic Diocese of Uromi presented Start-Up materials to 30 beneficiaries of the Sustainable Measure Against Trafficking in Person (SMAT-P) project. The beneficiaries include those who were trained in Tailoring, Hair Dressing, Welding, ICT, Carpentry, Diesel Mechanic, Machine Mechanic, Building and Auto Craft, among others. The objective of the project is to

see that Persons vulnerable to human trafficking are supported to live a more meaningful and productive lives within target communities.



Beneficiaries standing by the items received

Uromi JDPCI partnered with Caritas Nigeria to implement this intervention tagged Sustainable Measure against Trafficking in Person (SMAT-P) which was sponsored by the Catholic Bishop Conference of Italy. The focus of the intervention was on the prevention of human trafficking, protection and the reintegration of victims of human trafficking in Esan South East and Esan Central LGAs. The intervention was also designed to improve the livelihood opportunity and living condition of vulnerable households by creating alternatives for them.

The project which had in the previous year strengthened the livelihood of 96 households by supporting them with the sum of fifty thousand naira each to setup income generating activity of their choice, took a step further to empower 30 youths who have successfully completed their vocational skills acquisition training with startup materials and six months store rent. This start up materials are to enable them setup their own trade for improved livelihood and meaningful living



Beneficiaries standing by their items

thereby making them less susceptible to human trafficking and irregular migration.

The Executive Director Very Rev Fr Dr Fidelis Arhedo, in his opening remark gave a rundown of the project achievement which include the sensitization of sixty one communities, fifty nine schools, eleven markets, eight churches and 2 mosques on the dangers of human trafficking and irregular migration. He added that one hundred and thirty eight secondary school students and six tertiary education students were also given one year scholarship by the project.

Very Rev Fr Dr Fidelis Arhedo on behalf of the Right - Holders, expressed his gratitude to all the partners for this great intervention in Uromi Diocese and admonished the beneficiaries to be committed to making judicious use of the equipment given to them

The Business startup equipment/materials presented to the beneficiaries include the following:

Tailoring Beneficiaries: Butterfly Sewing Machine, Peacock Charcoal Iron, Kemale 2200 Generator, Wooden Table And Stool and Sewing Kit (needles, 12 thread, a pack of office pins, a pack of needles, tape, scissors, elastic, tailors chalk)



A beneficiaries receiving gift from the Vicar Very Rev Fr Francis Omolumen

Welding Beneficiaries: Maxmech Inverter Welding Machine, Filing Machine, Vase, Hand Saw (Poland), Maxmech) Drilling Machine, Sledge Hammer (Skyer), Chizle and Pouch

Diesel Mechanic Beneficiaries: Complete Tool Box (Unior) and Grinding Machine (Angle Grinder)

Hair Dressing Beneficiaries: Equator 3000 Hair Dryer, Elepaq EC.5800CXS, Wash Hair Basin, Plastic Table and Plastic Chairs

ICT Beneficiaries

1. Hp 15.6” Pentium 4GB/500GB Laptop-Scarlet Red

Building and Auto craft

1. HP Laptop 15-bs 130nia

Machine Mechanic Beneficiaries: Complete Tool Box(Unior), Vase and Drilling Machine

DON'T PAY WITH YOUR LIFE PROJECT

Uromi Justice Development Peace and Caritas Initiatives (Uromi JDPCI) Partnered with ECPAT France and ECPAT Luxemburg to prevent the susceptibility of adolescent girls and young women from Edo State to Human trafficking and sexual exploitation via the Project; Don't Pay With Your Life.

Within the Period under review Uromi JDPCI implemented a number of activities geared towards provision of psychosocial and economic support to female returnees. The activities include: Profiling and Assessment of 11 Young Female Returnees out of which 9 were selected after conducting Family Tracing and Reunification as well as series of Home Visit. The project team also conducted training for Business Start-up, Business Management and Entrepreneurship for the female returnees and the provision of business Start-up materials and equipment to 9 young female returnees

Also in the quarter, Uromi JDPCI awarded the Second Tranche of Grant for Income Generating Activities to 8 of the Caregivers who had satisfactory put to use the first grant that was given to them. Household assessment was also conducted for 12 households out of which 7 were selected for livelihood support as planned by the project

Business Management and Entrepreneurship Training for Young Female Returnees

As part of the preparation process for the provision of economic support to the young Female Returnees, Uromi JDPCI organised a two day training on Business Management and Entrepreneurship for the young female Returnees on the 12th – 13th of March 2021 at Uromi JDPCI Office Complex with the objective to equip the beneficiaries on how to be enterprising,



Training session for beneficiaries

start and manage businesses for profitability and sustainability.

The sessions were facilitated by Erhabor Harriet with



Group photograph with beneficiaries after training

attendance. The Topics covered in the course of training includes: Introduction to Business and Entrepreneurship, the concept of Marketing and its relevance in Business, the Basic Marketing Steps, Pricing Strategies, Keeping Business Records and Building Savings Culture. Also during the training, the Participants were guided to develop a life plan for their chosen businesses and they also signed a memorandum of understanding with Uromi JDPCI for the purpose of documenting the expectations from both Parties - (the Beneficiaries and Uromi JDPCI)

Empowers Female Returnees and Caregivers

Uromi Justice Development Peace and Caritas Initiatives sets up Nine 9 Young Female Returnees in business activities as part of the reintegration assistance for Survivors of human Trafficking under the project; “Don’t Pay With Your Life” (DPWYL). Eight (8) caregivers were also supported with 50,000 grant to further boost the income generating activities which they were given money to establish in June, 2020 as part of efforts to prevent human trafficking among secondary school students in Edo



Executive Director addressing beneficiaries

Central Senatorial District. The event was held on the 30th of March, 2021 at Uromi JDPCI, located at Catholic Chancery complex, Egbele, Uromi, Edo- State. This support is geared towards empowering young female returnees with start-up kits in their different skills/trade. Dignitaries at the event were the Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI, Very Rev. Fr. Dr. Fidelis Arhedo, his staff as well as the National/Regional Chairman of The Great Esan Returnees Association, Mr. Brown Okojie. The Don’t Pay With Your Life” (DPWYL) program is operated by ECPAT France, ECPAT Luxembourg and Uromi JDPCI; co-financed by *The Agence Française de Développement*, the Ministry of Foreign and European Affairs of Luxembourg and other private donors, including Air France.

In a remark presented by Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI Very Rev Fr. Dr. Fidelis Arhedo, beneficiaries were advised to be focused, disciplined and diligent in their various choice of businesses. He explained that once they employed integrity, diligence, meticulous and assiduous approach to the business, their business would strive and stand the test of time; and as such becomes relevant and essential personnel in their immediate environment which would metamorphose into a larger opportunity due to recommendations from satisfied customers.



Group photograph with young female beneficiaries



Group photograph with caregivers who benefitted from IGA grant

He further advised them to shun ideas that would lead to the sales of the startup kit, stating that such actions would deflect the very aim of the empowerment, which was for reintegration and economic stability of the beneficiaries. He reminded them that the businesses they were to embark upon were not imposed on them by the

organization, but were choices made by themselves. He therefore stated that on that note, the organization would expect to see nothing other than fruitfulness in their business.

The president of the Greater Esan Returning



Executive Director, with a beneficiary standing by her Generator and Hair materials



Executive Director, with a beneficiary standing by her Generator and Hair materials

Association (GERA) further admonished the beneficiaries on the need to be steadfast, resilient and committed to the course of their full reintegration while seeing the livelihood support as an opportunity to fully realize their potentials in their various communities. He thanked Uromi JDPCI and her partners who provided the support for the beneficiaries and promised to assist in the monitoring of beneficiaries for effective utilization of the opportunity.

Commemoration of the feast day of St Josephine Bakhita: patroness saint of victims of slavery and human trafficking

Uromi JDPCI marked the feast of St Josephine Bakhita with a sensitization on the 8th of February, 2021. The event was held to raise awareness on the dangers of human trafficking and irregular migration as well as pray for those who are victims of slavery or human trafficking and those who lost their lives in captivity as victims of slavery or human trafficking. Key stakeholders from selected communities and Members of the Great Esan Returnees Association (an association of returned migrants) among others were present at the event.

In the key note address, the Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI, Very Rev Fr. Dr. Fidelis Arhedo noted that despite the serious campaigns, awareness creation and sensitization of the general populace on the ills of human trafficking, irregular migration and child labour, the menace still persists because of economic hardship in the country. He admonished participants not to allow the precarious economic situation expose them to human trafficking because of the dangers inherent in it. He recounted some of the efforts that Uromi JDPCI in collaboration with her partners have made to ameliorate the harsh economic situation of victims and vulnerable youth so as to make them less susceptible to human trafficking and irregular migration. He added that this support will continue until the desired situation is achieved

He thereafter gave a brief history of St. Josephine Bakhita who triumphed from slavery to the dignity of a child of God and bride of Christ unto sainthood. A young girl, who was born in Sudan, captured by slave traders, sold and resold severally that she could not remember her name

anymore until she fell into the hand of an Italian Master where she was given the name Bakhita and at baptism she got the name Josephine.

Rev Fr Fidelis Arhedo urged all to emulate the virtues of Bakhita who even in her predicament upheld human dignity and demonstrated extreme kindness by always and all times caring and praying for the oppressed. She allowed love to heal her heart such that she refused to kill her oppressors even when she had the opportunity, because of her kindheartedness.

Her encounter with the Canossian Sisters of Charity further drew her heart to God and consumed by her love for God she lived her life for the service of the oppressed, lonely, rejected and abandoned. She conquered slavery and oppression and became a shining advocate of genuine emancipation and a bride of Christ. It was emphasized that it was her care for other people that made her a saint not merely because she was a Rev Sister.

Very Rev Fr Dr Fidelis Arhedo concluded that the history of the life of St Bakhita should inspire us not just for passive acceptance but the firm resolve to work effectively to free girls and women from oppression, human trafficking and violence and return them to their dignity in the full exercise of their rights.

Prayers and hymns led by Rev Fr. Ferdinand Ovielonba were thereafter offered for victims to find solace, Perpetrators to have a change of heart and embrace repentance and strength for those fighting against the crime, so as to be resilient in their efforts. A movie on the life and time of St Josephine Bakhita was shown to the participants who watched with keen interest the humane qualities of the person of St. Bakhita who conquered and overcame the difficulties and sufferings of slavery and human trafficking. A young girl, who progressed from a zero position in life to that of a hero and from slavery to Sainthood.

Participants thereafter expressed firm trust in their ability to overcome whatever difficulties the economic situation of the country may put before them and resist all forms of enticement to this modern day slavery known as human trafficking.

Annual Parish JDPC Meeting

The annual meeting of the parish JDPC was held on the 18th of February 2021 at the Chancery hall, Egbele, Uromi. The meeting was convened to serve as an avenue to revive parish JDPCs and share new information about JDPC as well as getting them involved in the activities of Uromi JDPCI. The participants included the deanery JDPC chairman of Ubiaja Deanery, local government supervisors, JDPC members from different parishes and staff of Uromi JDPCI

In the opening remark delivered by very Rev. Fr. Dr. Fidelis Arhedo, the Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI, it was noted that the purpose of the meeting was to map out the way forward for Parish JDPC in Uromi Diocese, revive the lukewarm parish JDPC groups and create new ones in

parishes where they do not exist so as to have a strong volunteer force working to establish the face of Christ in our parishes.

In his address, he made a distinction on the mandate of Parish JDPC and St. Vincent de Paul. He exemplified this difference by noting that while JDPC provides the means to get food so that one can continue to feed, St. Vincent de Paul gives you the food. Hence, there is need to strengthen the operations of Parish JDPCs in our parishes to intervene in emergencies and crisis as well as to collaborate with Uromi JDPCI in the implementation of her interventions.

He explained that Uromi JDPCI has the mission to alleviate poverty, and promote integral development through the motivation and empowerment of the less privileged/oppressed and challenging unjust structures that enhance injustice, hatred and backwardness in Nigeria which stems from her vision to have a peaceful and developed society where there is peaceful coexistence and promotion of human rights and empowerment of the people for meaningful living.

He expressed sadness over past experiences as he had tried to work with parish JDPCs but there were no results, thus he engaged people outside the church which has yielded successful result. He noted that we have gathered here in hope to discuss our expectations and issues.

Rev Fr Fidelis Arhedo urged all JDPC members to go through the institute of theological studies (ITS) to be able to understand the Catholic social teaching which will better inform their understanding of JDPC and Its apostolate.

In the course of the meeting, problems were raised and solutions were suggested and discussed

Interim deanery executives were appointed for the five deaneries to oversee the activities of all the parishes under their various deaneries. Mr P.O Imhontu, Bar Dan Akhidenor and Mr Eimuhi were to coordinate Ubiaja, Irrua and Ekpoma Deaneries respectively

The newly appointed executives and the participants thereafter promised to assist in the creation of JDPC in parishes close to them and also put hands together with the parish Priest to device ways to carry out the true mandate of Uromi JDPCI which will better the lives of the church, community and the society at large.

ADDRESSING VULNERABILITY THROUGH VOCATIONAL TRAINING AND EMPOWERMENT IN IGUEBEN LGA

The project Addressing Vulnerability through Vocational Training and Empowerment is aimed at providing household economic strengthening for orphaned and vulnerable children (OVC) with the Objective to support vocational skill acquisition and business start-up for 30 Persons comprising OVC, OVC Caregivers and Older OVCs in Igueben Local Government Area of Edo State as well as to secure vocational skill training free of charge or in part for additional 90 persons by the 30 beneficiaries of the Program.

The Project was funded by the United States of America Department of State (US Embassy) and implemented by Uromi Justice Development Peace and Caritas Initiatives (Uromi JDPCI)

Some of the activities implemented in the project includes: Advocacy/Sensitization to communities, Identification/ Selection of Beneficiaries, verification/Assessment of Beneficiaries, Signing of Memorandum of Understanding with Beneficiaries, Meeting with the Beneficiaries and the Community Implementation Team/Volunteers and Empowerment of Beneficiaries with start-up materials.

Empowerment of Beneficiaries in Igueben with Start-Up Materials

On the 20th of January 2021, The Executive Director and staff of Uromi Justice Development Peace and Caritas Initiatives went to the town of Igueben after several months of preparations, to empower twenty five (25) out of the (30) Beneficiaries of the intervention with startup materials for different skills previously acquired to enable them kick start their own businesses. The empowerment was to aid and support their means of livelihood, encouraging them to make use of their God given talent by engaging in honest labour to earn a living for themselves. This feat was made possible via the Federal Assistance Award by the U.S Department of State (US Embassy).



The Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI giving the welcome address

The event was graced by the king of Igueben kingdom; Zaiki Ehizojie Eiluojerio, the Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI; Very



During the Opening Prayer for the event

Rev. Fr. Dr. Fidelis Arhedo, Staff of

Uromi JDPCI, President and Executives of the Igueben Progressive youths, Members of the Community Implementation Team and the Beneficiaries. In the opening speech, Very Rev. Fr. Dr. Fidelis Arhedo thanked the King for taking out time to be present and expressed gratitude for all his previous efforts towards ensuring a better life for the youths; not just of Igueben kingdom but also Esan land at Large and for being a very strong and reliable pillar of the people.

He illustrated that a hungry Child who has no livelihood opportunities would be forced to thread on the part of irregular migration or fall prey to human



HRH presenting items to a hairdressing skill beneficiary

traffickers in a bid to be like his fellows who just travelled out of the country without any job or



Fr. Arhedo making presentation to a beneficiary of tailoring skill

business security but comes back with a lot of money. He recounted the efforts of Uromi JDPCI in combating this ugly trend across Esan Communities when in 2014, Uromi JDPCI created a skill acquisition platform which enrolled youths to learn different skills such as tailoring, hairdressing, soap making amongst others and 14 of those youths were empowered by Caritas Nigeria in 2016. Again through ECPAT France, the Organisation empowered 125 vulnerable households with livelihood support for the Caregivers and Educational support for their children. He noted that the reason he was talking about human trafficking on a day like this was because it has been observed that OVC are more susceptible to human trafficking.

Furthermore, he explained that the Award Provisions was indirectly planned for the empowerment of 90 persons. This is because the 30 persons that will be empowered were expected to train at least three other persons for free or at 50% discount as their own contribution to the project, by so doing the target of 90 persons will be met.

Consequently, he said that we were gathered to present the Start-up materials to the Beneficiaries and also pay their rent for six months to enable them start their businesses which would keep them busy and help them find bearing in life. He called on the King to help admonish the Beneficiaries to use these support judiciously so as to create a livelihood for themselves and have a brighter future which would mean a more prosperous land.



HRH making presentation to a beneficiary

His Royal Highness, Ehizojie Eiluojerio in his reply asserted that all his efforts have been to make sure that his kingdom grows for the better. He appreciated the



Very Rev. Fr. Fidelis Arhedo making presentation to one of the tailoring beneficiary

Bishop of Uromi Diocese and the

Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI for their continued support to the Igueben people in different aspects and prayed God for continued zeal to do more, not just for the people of Igueben but the land of Esan at large. He also acknowledged that some the Beneficiaries were the youths he had earlier sent for training.

The Royal Highness cautioned the beneficiaries that the palace would not have been involved in this empowerment if it was not genuine. Thus, he urged them to not disappoint him and Igueben community.

He advised the beneficiaries to continuously work hard to remain at the top as well as secure God's lifting, adding that no matter how little the empowerment is, it was left to them to work

hard to be able to double it and make it bountiful. He illustrated that just like the parable of the king in the bible, he would sit in his palace to watch and monitor from afar how each person will use the materials given.

He further admonished them to give back to the community what has been given to them, by not just training two persons for free as requested of them but they should train three persons, so that these 30 would not just be the beneficiaries alone but also their families and the entire Igueben at large would be the beneficiaries.



HRH presenting Start-up materials to a Barbing Beneficiary

He expressed his profound appreciation to the donor agency for this gesture by saying thank you to them in Igueben language. Thereafter the presentation was made to the Beneficiaries

MICRO CREDIT

Uromi JDPCI continues to play her role in the empowerment of the less privileged across Esan communities by offering soft loans to farmers and small business owners for enterprise development through her Micro Credit Scheme.



Monitoring visit to beneficiaries

These soft loans are given to groups as well as registered cooperative societies who are into active economic activities. Each group consists of poor active women and active farmers in the society. The Scheme is opened to Catholics and Non-Catholics within the Diocese of Uromi.



Micro credit officer with a group of beneficiaries

The Scheme is in four (4) platforms namely: Group Micro-Credit, PROMIC I, PROMIC II and AGRIC PROMIC (for farmers only). It is a basic requirement that the Beneficiaries form themselves into self-selected group before they are considered for assessment and training. Upon successful registration, validation and documentations, the members of the group then qualify to get soft loan which must be disbursed to them through their bank account.

The scheme has supported 1,430 persons across 116 groups in different communities. Presently, the scheme has 55 active groups with a total of 537 persons benefiting from the different schemes.